wife. About an hour later, the *Rajmahal* sidled up to the wharf on the eastern bank, the stately but slightly tumbledown Wasif Manzil serving as bait to lure curious travellers journeying up the river. Jumping into a seemingly endless supply of tongas and totos along the sunny waterfront, we filed excitedly into town.

The former capital of Bengal, Murshidabad is a heady dose of history, cultural exchange and the arts. The Mughal emperor Akbar founded the city, then called Makhsudabad—and later Aurangzeb had the capital shifted here from Dhaka, under the stewardship of Murshid Quli Khan, the erstwhile nawab. He was buried at the Katra Masjid, a former caravanserai that came up to service the vast hordes of traders that would pass through or arrive here during the 1720s.

Built in 1837 in a combination of Greek and Italian classical styles, the one-thousand-door Hazarduari Palace is a hulking edifice that now functions as a museum exhibiting priceless antiques, weaponry and personal possessions of royalty. It is, however, the three-storey, palm-flanked Kathgola Palace that I had always associated this city with; and once we trundled up to the splendid Georgian-style palace, surrounded by a sprawling mango plantation, I heard about Murshidabad's Jain connection—this palatial timber godown (kath-gola) was constructed by Rai Bahadur Lakshmipat Singh Dugar, a Marwari Jain trader from Rajasthan.

In Nashipur, close to Hazarduari Palace, we visited the 'House of Jagat Seth' museum—the former residence of the family of Murshid Quli Khan's first banker, Seth Manik Chand. In the past 300 years, the community has become an important ingredient of the local salad bowl and come to be known as the Sheherwalis (city dwellers).

The Sheherwalis have played an active role in preserving and promoting Murshidabad's heritage before the world. On the cruise later that night, we met the passionate Darshan Dudhoria who hails from one of the pioneering Sheherwali families in town (most of whom have moved to Kolkata). The eloquent Darshan joined us on the cruise for a meet-and-greet and a preliminary briefing about the Murshidabad experience, and what the Bari Kothi, his ancestral house on the west bank of the river, has brought to the city. In the morning, we again boarded the wooden ferry to get to the Jiaganj-Azimganj side of town, where the Bari Kothi staff braved the drizzle at the riverbank to escort us to the gorgeous hotel premises.

At the lobby, we were given an elaborate welcome, including a welcome scroll that amusingly addressed the men in the group with the title 'babu'. As we stepped into the courtyard for a tour, the heavens finally opened up, heightening the period-romance glow cast all over the late-17th century mansion, which opened up as a heritage hotel in 2018. A captivating melange of architectural aesthetics and elements—corridors shaded by panelled blinds, stunning chandeliers above and patterned tiles below, ornate columns and brightly painted walls—unfolded before the background score of the monsoon.

Moments before I caught a quick nap at my suite before a long drive back to Kolkata, my mind went back to Palashi, and the sly role the Jagat Seths—the financiers of Bengal's nawabs—played in Siraj-ud-Daulah's loss to Robert Clive. Perhaps the answer lay in *Siddhartha*: "It is not for me to judge another man's life. I must judge, I must choose, I must spurn, purely for myself. For myself, alone." ■





OLD MEETS NEW The spacious dining room on the *Rajmahal* (left); visitors at the Hooghly Imambara (above)

INDRANEEL MAJUMDAR